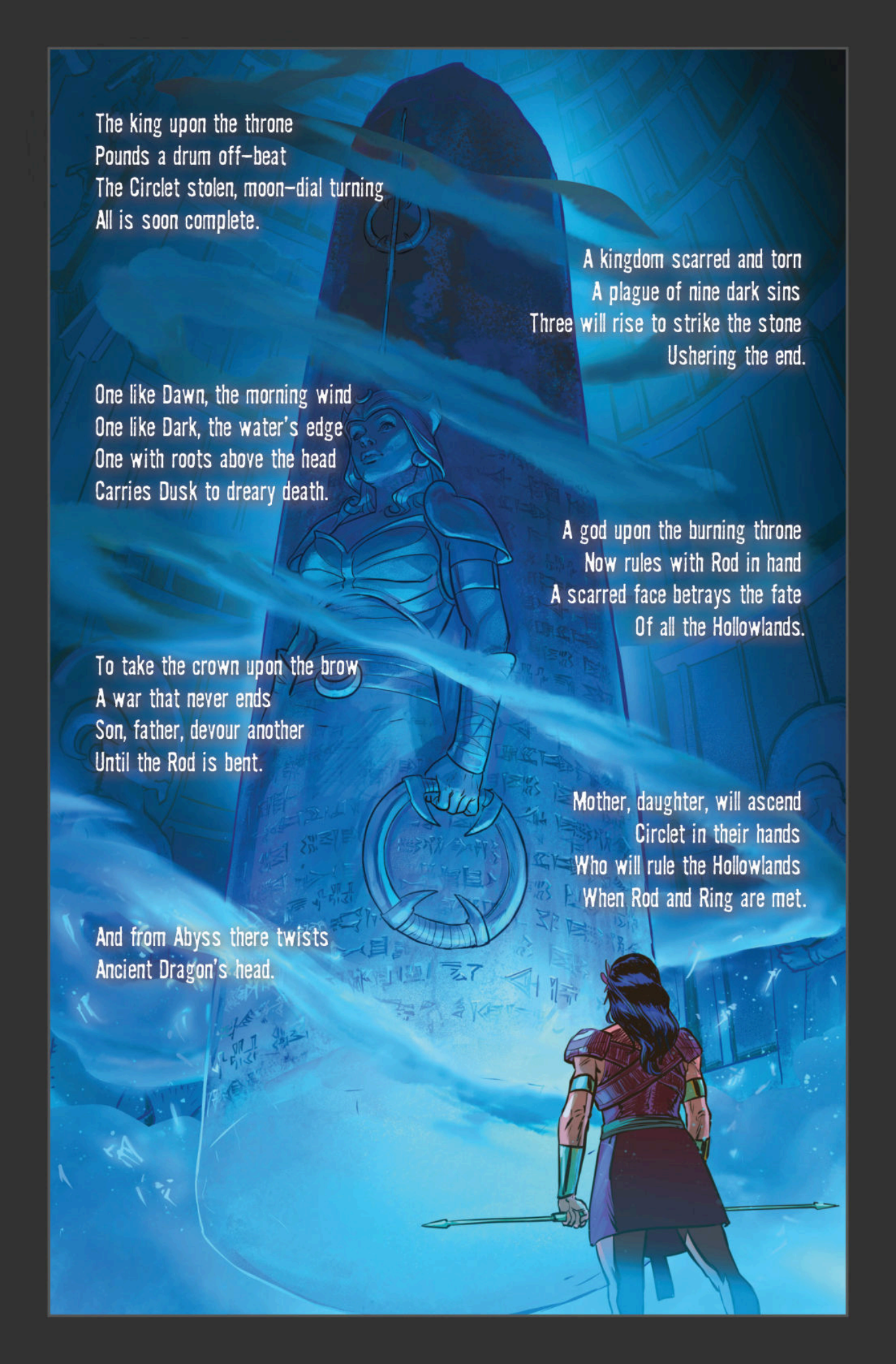


CHAPTER 2





The king upon the throne
Pounds a drum off-beat
The Circlet stolen, moon-dial turning
All is soon complete.

A kingdom scarred and torn
A plague of nine dark sins
Three will rise to strike the stone
Ushering the end.

One like Dawn, the morning wind
One like Dark, the water's edge
One with roots above the head
Carries Dusk to dreary death.

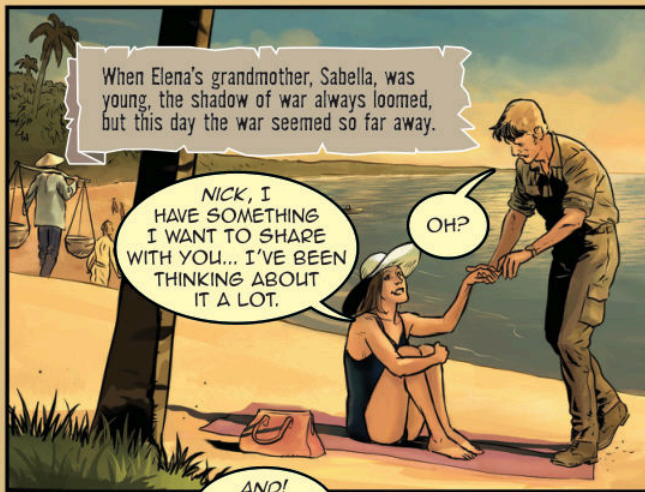
A god upon the burning throne
Now rules with Rod in hand
A scarred face betrays the fate
Of all the Hollowlands.

To take the crown upon the brow
A war that never ends
Son, father, devour another
Until the Rod is bent.

Mother, daughter, will ascend
Circlet in their hands
Who will rule the Hollowlands
When Rod and Ring are met.

And from Abyss there twists
Ancient Dragon's head.

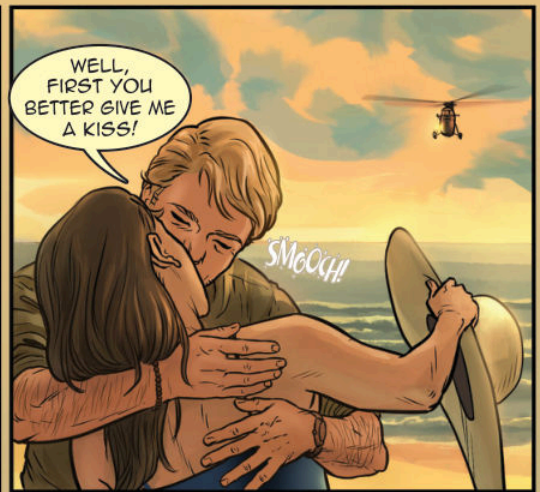




When Elena's grandmother, Sabella, was young, the shadow of war always loomed, but this day the war seemed so far away.

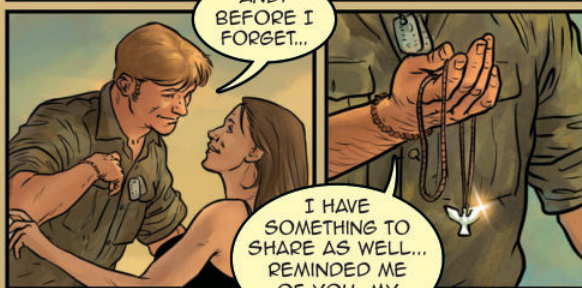
NICK, I HAVE SOMETHING I WANT TO SHARE WITH YOU... I'VE BEEN THINKING ABOUT IT A LOT.

OH?



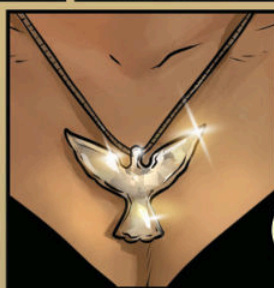
WELL, FIRST YOU BETTER GIVE ME A KISS!

SMOOCH!



AND! BEFORE I FORGET...

I HAVE SOMETHING TO SHARE AS WELL... REMINDED ME OF YOU, MY DOVE.



HONEY... THANK YOU!



These moments of paradise were fleeting, and then...

SORRY TO INTERRUPT YOU TWO LOVE-BIRDS... WE HAVE AN URGENT SITUATION... WE'LL NEED YOU ON POINT, NICK.

DO YOU SEE WHAT I HAVE TO PUT UP WITH, LOVE? COMPLETE INCOMPETENCY. THEY ALWAYS NEED ME TO HOLD THEIR HAND.



I'LL TELL HIM NEXT TIME THAT I'M PREGNANT.



PLEASE, PLEASE, BE SAFE OUT THERE, LOVE.

...they were gone like the wind's dust.



But the wind carries many things,
and so it bore two travelers into the shadow...

WHAT
A PRETTY
DOVE...

AHH!...
AND WHAT
A TERRIFYING
CREATURE FROM
MY DARKEST
NIGHTMARE!

ELENA,
WE MUST MAKE
CAMP SOON AND
IT IS BETTER HERE
THAN IN THE OPEN
GRASSLANDS.

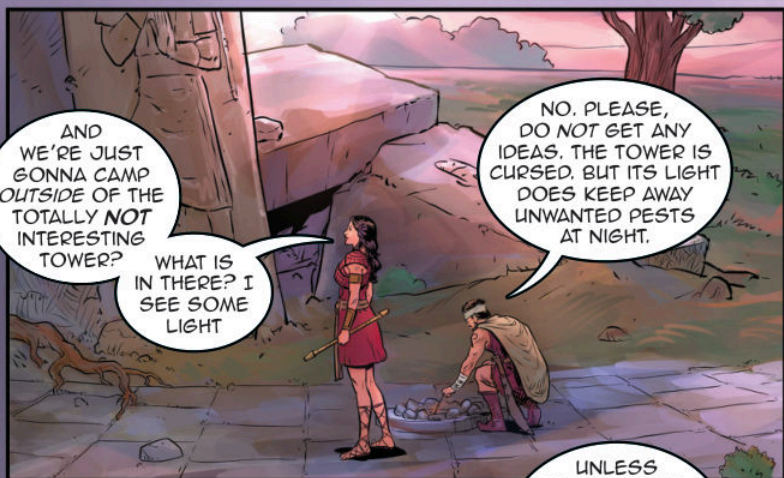
SHOOOR



...of the footstool of the gods.

WHAT
IS THIS
PLACE?

NOTHING
MUCH NOW...
USED TO BE
GLORIOUS.



AND
WE'RE JUST
GONNA CAMP
OUTSIDE OF THE
TOTALLY NOT
INTERESTING
TOWER?

WHAT IS
IN THERE? I
SEE SOME
LIGHT

NO. PLEASE,
DO NOT GET ANY
IDEAS. THE TOWER IS
CURSED. BUT ITS LIGHT
DOES KEEP AWAY
UNWANTED PESTS
AT NIGHT.



AW,
C'MON, NO
TOUR?

UNLESS
YOU WANT US
TO BE CURSED
BY THE NINE. IT IS
VERY BAD LUCK TO
TREAD ON THAT
GROUND



THE NINE? THE NINE WHAT? KINGS?

THERE ARE NINE CRUEL GODS ATRUS NIL SERVES... ESPECIALLY IRRA, GOD OF WAR... CROSS THEIR SERVANTS, AND YOU DON'T GET A WARNING.

SO THERE WAS A BIG WAR OR SOMETHING?

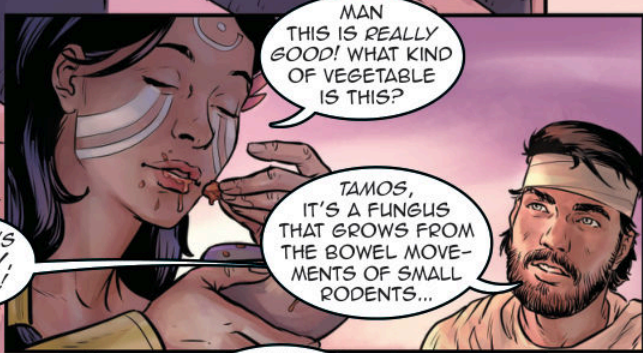
NOT A WAR. A MASSACRE. THE MAGUS WERE SCHOLARS, NOT SOLDIERS. KEEPERS OF ANCIENT WISDOM. THEIR SPIRITS STILL DO NOT SLEEP.



YOU MEAN LIKE THESE GUYS WITH THE LONG PONY TAILS?

YES. ADVISORS TO THE OLD KINGS, THEN THE TITAN LORDS. THEY REBELLED. ATRUS NIL HUNTED THEM DOWN ONE BY ONE. THE MAGUS ARE NOTHING BUT A MEMORY NOW.

DINNER'S READY, ELENA!



MAN THIS IS REALLY GOOD! WHAT KIND OF VEGETABLE IS THIS?

TAMOS, IT'S A FUNGUS THAT GROWS FROM THE BOWEL MOVEMENTS OF SMALL RODENTS...



HEY! YOU WOULD DO WELL NOT TO WASTE GOOD FOOD! HERE, LET ME FETCH YOU SOME WATER.

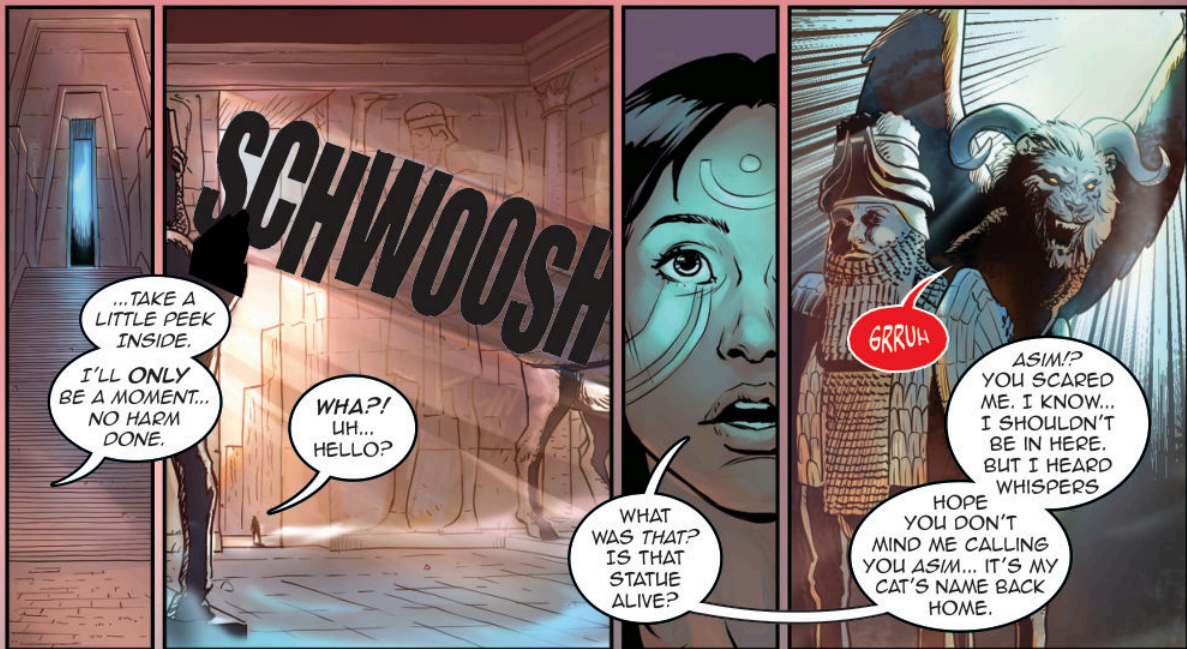
ELENA, STAY HERE OK?

BLECK!



OK, OK, NO TOWER, GOT IT. WEIRD... DO I HEAR WHISPERS FROM... I'LL JUST...





...TAKE A LITTLE PEEK INSIDE.

I'LL ONLY BE A MOMENT... NO HARM DONE.

WHA?! UH... HELLO?

WHAT WAS THAT? IS THAT STATUE ALIVE?

GRRUH

ASIM!? YOU SCARED ME. I KNOW... I SHOULDN'T BE IN HERE, BUT I HEARD WHISPERS

HOPE YOU DON'T MIND ME CALLING YOU ASIM... IT'S MY CAT'S NAME BACK HOME.



OH WOOW... WHAT IS THIS PLACE?

THAT ROCK! IT'S FLOATING!

I HEAR MORE WHISPERS!... OH C'MON, ASIM, YOU LET ME COME **THIS** FAR. NO WAY I'M TRADING THIS FOR A FIRESIDE CHAT WITH RAMBO.

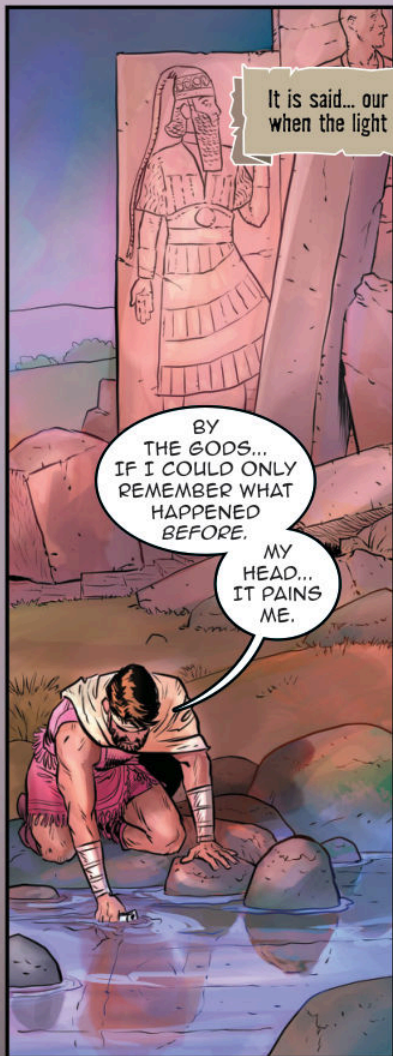


I WONDER IF THESE ARE THE STATUES OF THE NINE?



GRRUH

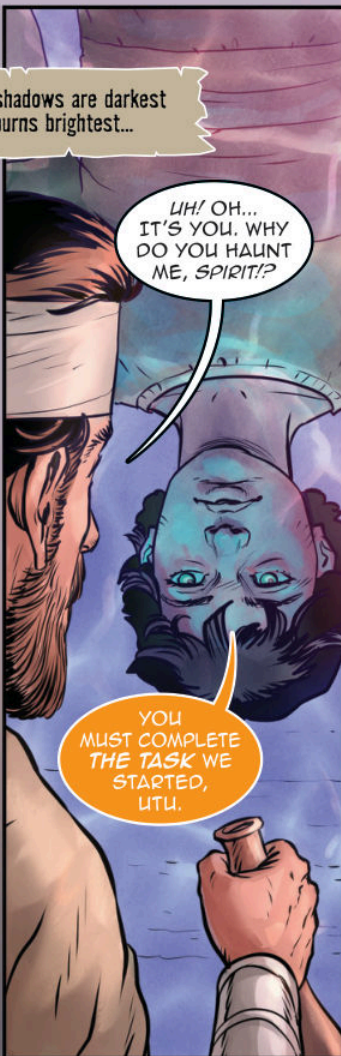
WOAH! I CAN SEE THE CRACKS.



It is said... our shadows are darkest when the light burns brightest...

BY THE GODS... IF I COULD ONLY REMEMBER WHAT HAPPENED BEFORE.

MY HEAD... IT PAINS ME.



UH! OH... IT'S YOU. WHY DO YOU HAUNT ME, SPIRIT!?

YOU MUST COMPLETE THE TASK WE STARTED, UTU.



WHY MUST YOU HARASS ME? HAVE YOU NOT TAKEN ENOUGH FROM ME? THIS IS NOT MY BURDEN.

And all too often, it is the shadow in the soul....



...that is darkest of all.

WHERE DID SHE GO? ELENA!?



YOU MUST FIND HER, UTU, BEFORE SHE...

The Maxim, which floated above dials and gears, then revealed its great age by the souls, often the Sightless, that drift through its cracked facade from other realms.

THIS PLACE IS CREEPY, ASIM. WHAT ARE THOSE PEDESTAL THINGS NEAR THE CENTER?

THE SYMBOLS... THEY LOOK LIKE THE ONES ON MY WEAPON.

IT LOOKS LIKE IT FITS RIGHT H-WOAH!

WSHSH WSHH

KEHUNK

KEHUNK

UH...OH... CRAP.

TEK...TEK

SWEET ONE, I KNEW THAT YOU WOULD FIND YOUR WAY HERE.

ZZZ

GRAND-MOTHER? IS THAT YOU? YOU LOOK MUCH YOUNGER.

HER IMAGE IS FADING! WAIT... HOW DO I FIND YOU?

ELENA, PREPARE YOURSELF; A GREAT TRIAL APPROACHES! THE BLOOD MOON IS RISING! I MUST GO NOW....

GREAT... JUST LIKE THAT. SHE'S GONE!

WAIT... ARE THOSE PIECES OF THE FLOATING STONE!?

TEK...TEK



Elena could not have known that an unseen power had awakened, forcing the machine into painful motion. And now... that hideous clock was ticking.



IT HAS NOW
BEGIN!

UHH...
ASIM... IS THIS
SUPPOSED TO BE
HAPPENING?



IT IS
NOT TIME!
SHE MUST BE
STOPPED!



GRRRR

ROAAARR



WHAT
IN THE?





SIGH...SORRY FOR LOSING MY TEMPER, ELENA. THE MAXIM STONE HAS BEEN WEAKENING FOR MANY CENTURIES. WHEN IT LOSES ITS POWER, THAT WILL MARK THE BEGINNING OF THE END OF THIS WORLD AND YOURS.

NOW I SEE WHY YOU YELLED. I'M SORRY, UTU.

IT IS ALRIGHT... HERE, I THINK YOU SHOULD WEAR **THIS**. I WAS ONCE THE LEADER OF A SMALL REBEL GROUP THAT FOUGHT THE DOMINION.

WE LOST. THEY ARE ALL GONE NOW.

THAT IS SAD. I KNOW WHAT IT IS LIKE TO LOSE THOSE YOU CARE FOR.

THIS WAS OUR CLAN'S SYMBOL. IT IS THE **LIFE TREE** AT THE CENTER OF THE WINDS. IT IS CONSIDERED BLASPHEMY BY THOSE WHO NOW RULE THE EMPIRE.

I GIVE IT TO YOU... MAY IT PROTECT YOU FROM THOSE WHO WISH YOU HARM.

THANK YOU, UTU. THAT MEANS A LOT.



WE CAN ASK. SIR!? SIR?!

EH?

UGH... MY LEGS ACHES... MAYBE WE CAN HITCH A RIDE WITH THAT FARMER?



LOOK! THAT HOUSE... IT'S ON FIRE!

BY THE GODS... I HOPE THIS IS NOT ANOTHER DOMINION INQUEST!

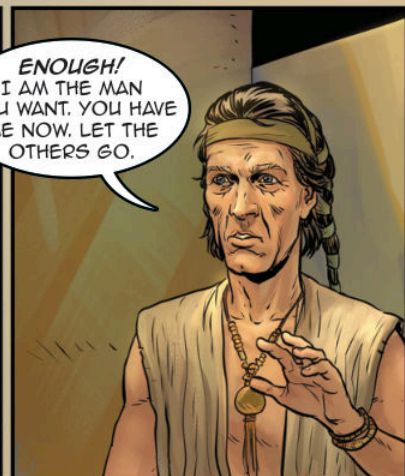


WE **MUST** BE CAUTIOUS. NO MORE RUNNING OFF ON YOUR OWN. I MEAN IT.

I WON'T... I REALLY DON'T KNOW WHAT CAME OVER ME BACK THERE. I'M USUALLY KIND OF A CHICKEN.

HEY, LET'S BORROW SOME OF THESE CLOTHES TO BLEND IN.

A SENSIBLE IDEA, ELENA. **GOOD THINKING!**





HUH!?

FATHER!
THERE YOU
ARE! WE NEED
TO GET YOU
HOME!



I
DO NOT
HAVE TIME FOR
THIS. KILL
HER!



WAIT! MY
FATHER IS NOT
WELL. HE WANDERED
FROM OUR
HOME.



L-LORD
ORION!
I...I...DID
NOT SEE YOU
ARRIVE. THIS-THESE
MAN IS WITH THE
SEDITIONIST
GROUP. HE IS A
MAGUS,
AND WE HAVE
BEEN...

WHAT IS
THE MEANING
OF ALL OF THIS
THEN?!

I SEE NO
MAGUS HERE! GO
NOW, WHILE YOU
STILL CAN! LEAVE
THESE PEOPLE
BE. UNLESS... YOU
WISH TO CALL ME
A LIAR?!

WHAT
THE-

YOU ARE
DECEIVED, MY
LORD! DECEIVED!
BUT... WE HAVE
OTHER BUSINESS
TO ATTEND TO...
WE GO!



LORD
ATRUS NUL
WILL HEAR
OF THIS



SIGH ...
I DID NOT MEAN
TO BRING HARM TO
THE GOOD PEOPLE
OF THIS TOWN...
I AM IN YOUR
DEBT... MANY
THANKS.

OF
COURSE...
WAIT... YOU REALLY
ARE THE FUGITIVE
MAGUS, AREN'T
YOU?





AHH...
THE QUEEN...
SHE SIMPLY ADORED
THESE FLOWERS.
WELL, USED
TO... OH!

SORRY,
BUT WILL
THE ORACLE
BE HERE
SOON?

I'M
TOO OLD AND
DISHEVELED,
HMM?.



WAIT...
YOU ARE ISIN
ADA?

I AM
SHE. AND YOU...
YOU ARE FROM THE
OTHER SIDE, AREN'T
YOU? WE HAVE GRAVE
THINGS TO DISCUSS,
BEARER OF THE
MARK.



WOAH!... SOME
KIND OF MAGICAL
POOL... THAT'S HER... SHE
LOOKS YOUNGER AND
POWERFUL.

I BELIEVE
THIS IS THE WOMAN
YOU'RE LOOKING FOR?
SHE WAS ONCE OUR
QUEEN.

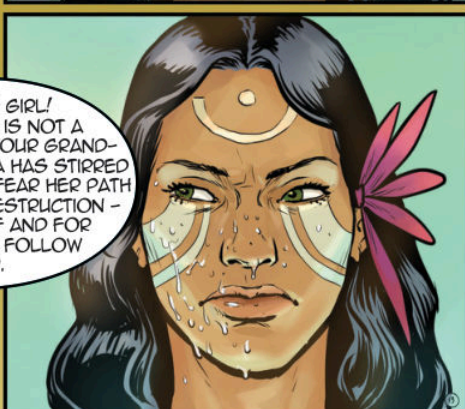
WAR HAS
CHANGED HER...
GONE ARE THE DAYS
WHEN THE WIND GUIDED
HER. SHE WALKS THE PATH
OF THE MOON NOW...
BUT I KNOW WHERE
SHE MAY BE
FOUND.



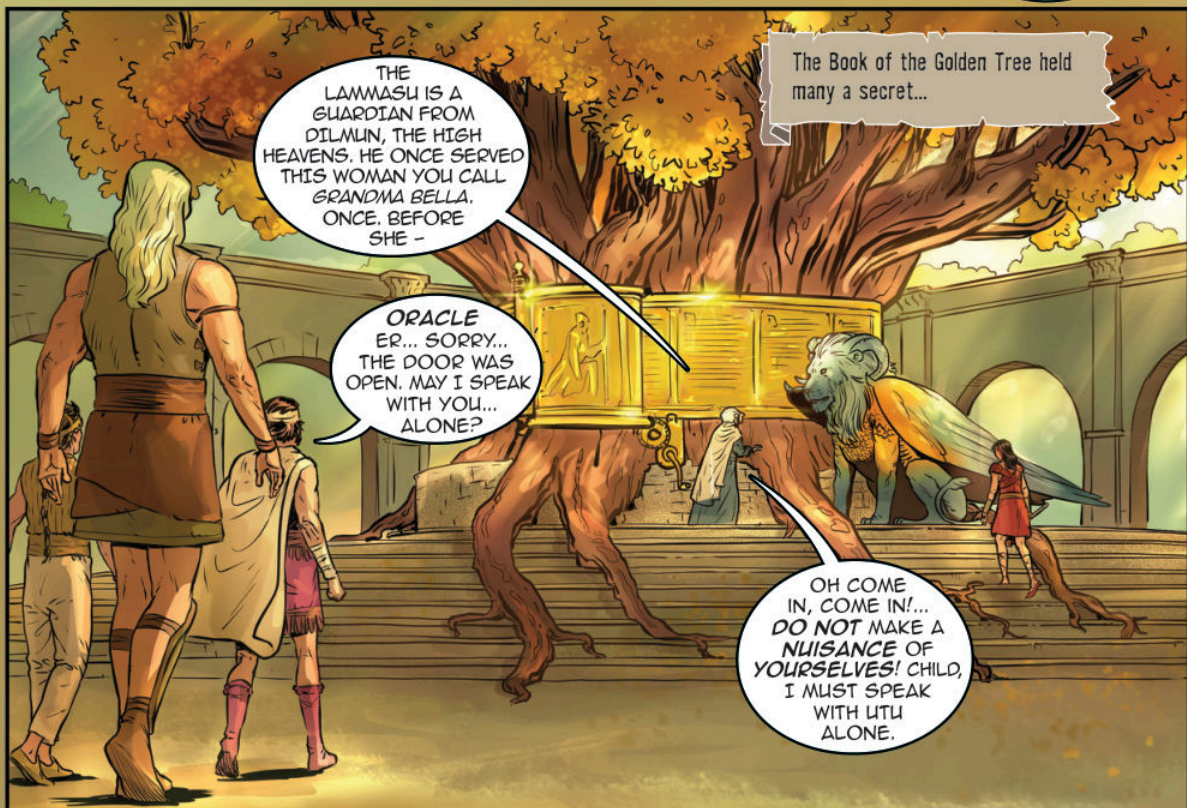
I
CANNOT
WAIT TO SEE
HER!



USH!?



FOOLISH GIRL!
THIS WORLD IS NOT A
PLAYGROUND! YOUR GRAND-
MOTHER SABELLA HAS STIRRED
DARK WATERS! I FEAR HER PATH
WILL LEAD TO DESTRUCTION -
FOR HERSELF AND FOR
THOSE WHO FOLLOW
HER.





WE ARE
IN NEED OF SKILLED
FIGHTERS IN OUR STRUGGLE
AGAINST BOTH DEMON AND
DOMINION TO PROTECT THIS
LAND FROM THEIR ADVANCE.
IT WOULD BE AN HONOR
IF YOU JOINED
US.

THANK
YOU, **ORION**...
BUT I HAVE TO FIND
MY GRANDMOTHER
AND RETURN
HOME.

IF IT WOULD
AID YOU TO FIND THIS
GRANDMOTHER, WE COULD
JOURNEY TOGETHER. WE WILL
NOT **SHRINK** BACK EVEN IF WE
SEE THE FEARSOME LUGAL
HIMSELF. WE HAVE BEEN A
THORN IN HIS SIDE AND
WILL BE **AGAIN**.

AND **THAT**
IS WHY YOU WERE
EXILED IN THE **FIRST**
PLACE, **ORION**. YOU ARE FAR
TOO **BRASH**, BUT IT WOULD
NOT HURT TO HAVE
SOME ADDED
SECURITY.



PERHAPS I
CAN HELP? YOU MAY
TAKE MY OLD **SKY SKIFF**...
THAT COULD HELP MAKE
THE JOURNEY FAR
ABOVE THAT DEADLY
WILDERNESS.



VERY
WELL, **ISIN ADA**.
I WILL SUPPLY US
WITH A CREW AND
SUPPLIES FOR THE
JOURNEY.

THE
SKY PATH
LEADS OVER THE
WESTERN WILDERNESS
TO THE CITY OF
SINN, WHERE THE
MOON QUEEN
PRESIDES.

IF THERE
IS A CHANCE OF A
FIGHT, YOU CAN COUNT
ON ME AND MY
WARRIORS.

I FEAR
THERE'S MORE
THAN JUST A **CHANCE**.
WHILE ON THE RUN, I
RECEIVED WORD THAT
ATRUS NUL'S FORCES ARE
MARCHING ON THE **MOON**
CITY! I ONLY HOPE WE
ARE NOT TOO
LATE!



THE TOWER... IT LOOKS AS THOUGH A STORM BREWS!

A STORM IS NOT COMING. IT IS ALREADY HERE! THE TIME OF THE BLOOD MOON IS AT HAND. IT WILL THREATEN YOUR WORLD AND OURS!

ELENA, IF YOU WANT TO COMPLETE YOUR MISSION, THEN YOU MUST BE TRAINED IN THE WAY OF MY ORDER.

UH... SO I'M TRAINING AGAINST HIM!?

INDEED. DO NOT FEAR HIM. WITH THAT SPEAR, YOUR GRANDMOTHER HAS GIVEN YOU THE POWER OF WIND GATHERING.



NOTHING TO WORRY ABOUT. JUST A HUGE GIANT MAN.

THE WIND MOVES, THEN YOU ACT IN UNISON. READY!?

I'M STRONGER THAN YOU—THERE'S NO GETTING AROUND THAT. YOU MUST LEARN TO BE FASTER AND SMARTER.



NOT A GOOD PLAN, ELENA!

WHAT... AM... I DOING?

LET YOUR REACTION BECOME ONE WITH THE ACTION.

YES, YES, BEND WITH THE WIND, DAUGHTER OF DAWN. STEEL YOURSELF WITH THE LIGHT. CAN YOU FEEL IT?!



UGH! OW! YES! I SURE DID FEEL IT.

WOW!...I ACTUALLY DID FEEL SOMETHING FLOW THROUGH ME... HOW DID I DEFEND MYSELF SO FAST!?

CLANG!



UGH!
IMPRESSIVE
SPEED AND
ACCURACY!

WHEN
THE WIND MOVES
YOU, THERE IS ONLY
CONFIDENT ACTION
AND EVEN YOUR
FEARS CANNOT
RESIST!!



GOOD...
GOOD!
THAT'S
IT!

THE
WIND **DOES**
INDEED MOVE
IN THIS ONE,
ORACLE!



THE MOON
QUEEN, YOUR
GRANDMOTHER, HAS
GROWN IN POWER. I
FEAR SHE HAS BORROWED
THE **POWER OF NINGAL**,
THE **GODDESS OF THE**
UNDERWORLD
HERSELF.

I HOPE
NOT. IF YOU CAN
REACH HER, MAYBE
YOU CAN BRING HER
BACK FROM THIS
FOLLY.

I'VE HEARD
WHISPERS THAT
THE MOON QUEEN
HOLDS THE **RING**
OF DARK,

AND THAT THE
EMPEROR, **ATRUS**
NUL, POSSESSES
THE **ROD OF**
DUK.



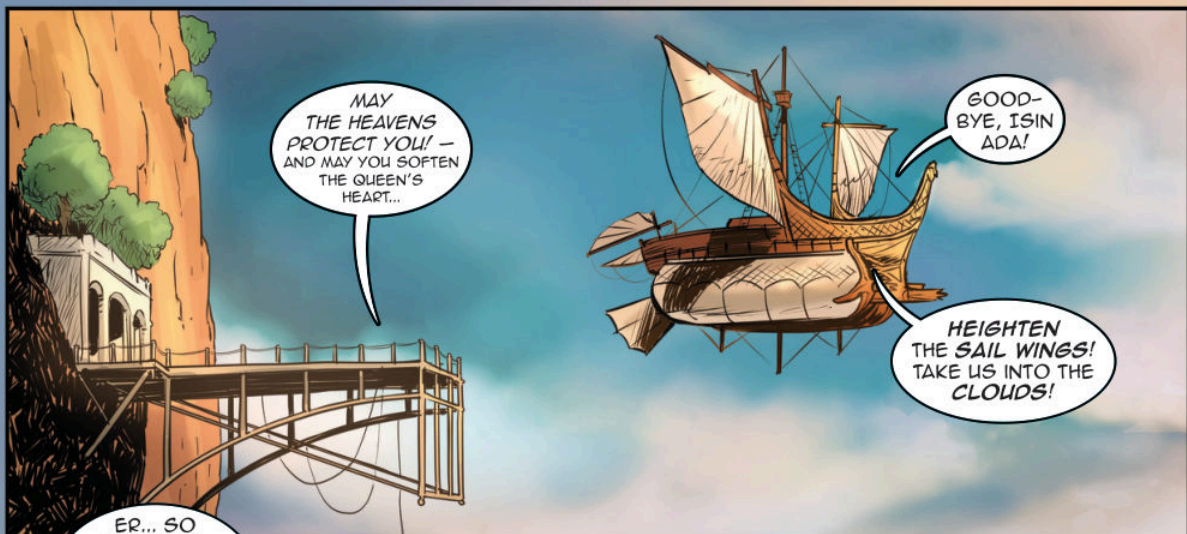
NO, NO,
GODDESS OF THE
UNDERWORLD?
SHE WOULDN'T
DO THAT.

SHOULD
THE TWO RELICS
BE HELD BY THE SAME
PERSON... IT WOULD GRANT
THE WIELDER ALMOST
UNLIMITED POWER AND
THIS WOULD MEAN A
DIRE FUTURE FOR
BOTH OF OUR
WORLDS.



HMM..
ROD AND RING?
ANCIENT SYMBOLS OF
KINGSHIP! I REMEMBER
READING THIS IN ART HISTORY
BUT SURELY GRANDMA BELLA
KNOWS OF THIS
DANGER?

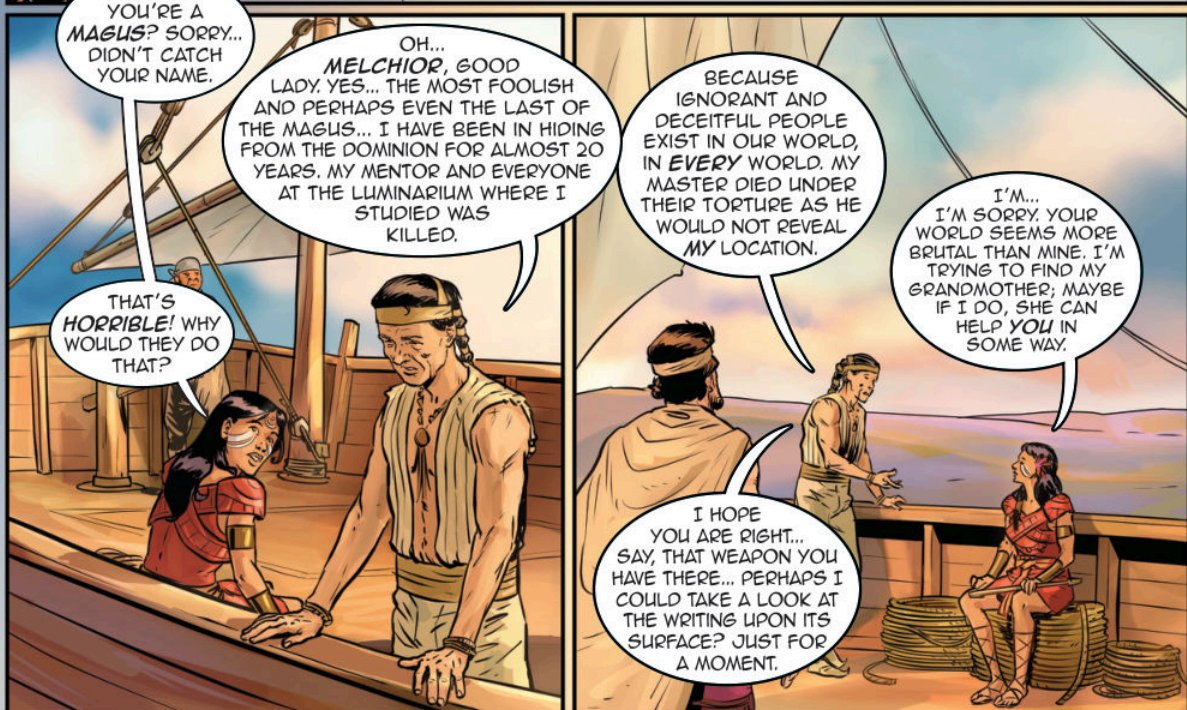
THE SKY
SKIFF IS READY TO
LEAVE... WHAT?
WHAT DID I MISS,
ELENA?



MAY
THE HEAVENS
PROTECT YOU! —
AND MAY YOU SOFTEN
THE QUEEN'S
HEART...

GOOD-
BYE, ISIN
ADA!

HEIGHTEN
THE SAIL WINGS!
TAKE US INTO THE
CLOUDS!



ER... SO
YOU'RE A
MAGUS? SORRY...
DIDN'T CATCH
YOUR NAME.

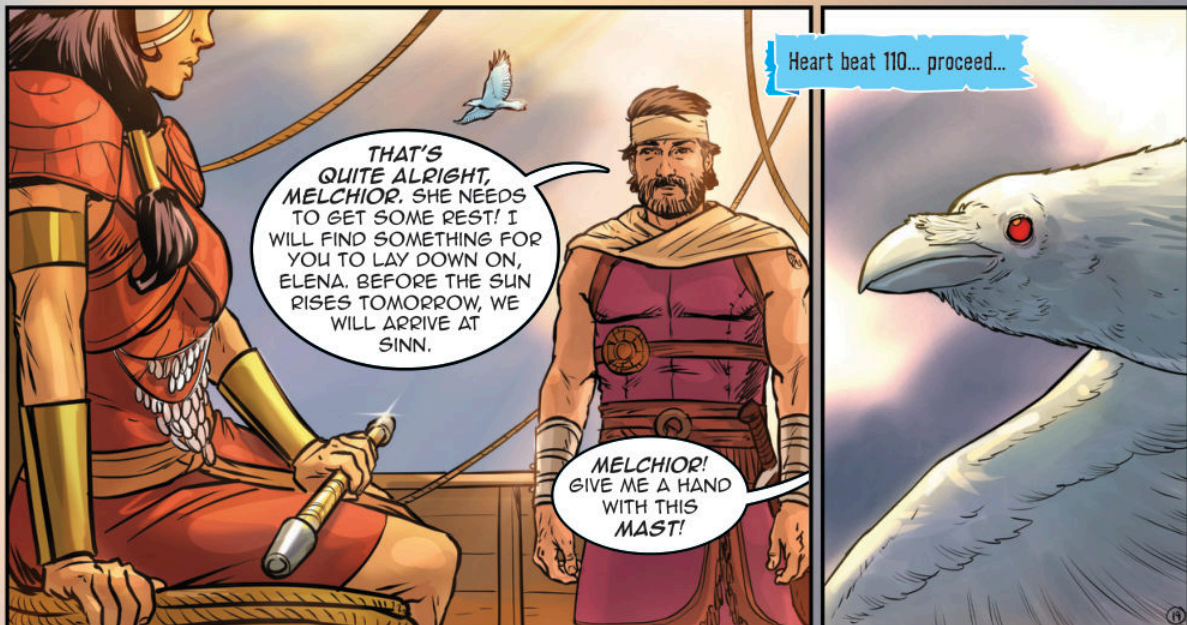
OH...
MELCHIOR, GOOD
LADY. YES... THE MOST FOOLISH
AND PERHAPS EVEN THE LAST OF
THE MAGUS... I HAVE BEEN IN HIDING
FROM THE DOMINION FOR ALMOST 20
YEARS. MY MENTOR AND EVERYONE
AT THE LUMINARIUM WHERE I
STUDIED WAS
KILLED.

THAT'S
HORRIBLE! WHY
WOULD THEY DO
THAT?

BECAUSE
IGNORANT AND
DECEITFUL PEOPLE
EXIST IN OUR WORLD,
IN *EVERY* WORLD. MY
MASTER DIED UNDER
THEIR TORTURE AS HE
WOULD NOT REVEAL
MY LOCATION.

I'M...
I'M SORRY. YOUR
WORLD SEEMS MORE
BRUTAL THAN MINE. I'M
TRYING TO FIND MY
GRANDMOTHER; MAYBE
IF I DO, SHE CAN
HELP YOU IN
SOME WAY.

I HOPE
YOU ARE RIGHT...
SAY, THAT WEAPON YOU
HAVE THERE... PERHAPS I
COULD TAKE A LOOK AT
THE WRITING UPON ITS
SURFACE? JUST FOR
A MOMENT.



Heart beat 110... proceed...

THAT'S
QUITE ALRIGHT,
MELCHIOR. SHE NEEDS
TO GET SOME REST! I
WILL FIND SOMETHING FOR
YOU TO LAY DOWN ON,
ELENA. BEFORE THE SUN
RISES TOMORROW, WE
WILL ARRIVE AT
SINN.

MELCHIOR!
GIVE ME A HAND
WITH THIS
MAST!

